04

PART 4 OF 9

The Promised Land

JOSH 1–24; JUDG 1–21; RUTH 1–4

From the crossing of the Jordan to the fields of Bethlehem: how a nation came to live in Canaan.



From the Jordan to Bethlehem

After Moses' death, the nation stands on the eastern bank of the Jordan, looking out over the promised land. The Book of Joshua tells of the entry into Canaan, the Book of Judges of several centuries of uncertain freedom, and the short Book of Ruth of a single family from Bethlehem. Together they form a story about a land that is a gift, but also a test. Picture a narrow strip of land between the sea and the desert, cut by valleys and hills. This terrain explains why some clashes were decided on the summits, others in the valleys, and why daily life unfolded in small, scattered settlements.

The geography of Canaan is surprisingly varied. In the west stretches a coastal plain, crossed by important trade routes. Farther inland rise the hills of Judah and Ephraim, hard to conquer but easy to defend. In the east opens the deep Jordan rift, and in the north the broad Jezreel Valley links the coast with the river. In such a landscape each generation received a different kind of land: pastures, grain fields, vineyards, or steep slopes. This mosaic favored independence but hindered unity, as the Book of Judges makes plain.

In this part of the atlas you will follow the stages of that journey: from the miraculous crossing of the Jordan, through Jericho, Ai, and Gibeon, to the assembly at Shiloh, where the land was divided among the twelve tribes. Later you will meet Deborah at Tabor, Gideon at the spring of Harod, and Samson in Gaza, and finally the humble fields of Bethlehem, where a story begins that leads to David. The reconstructions of places are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge, and distances are given as approximations.

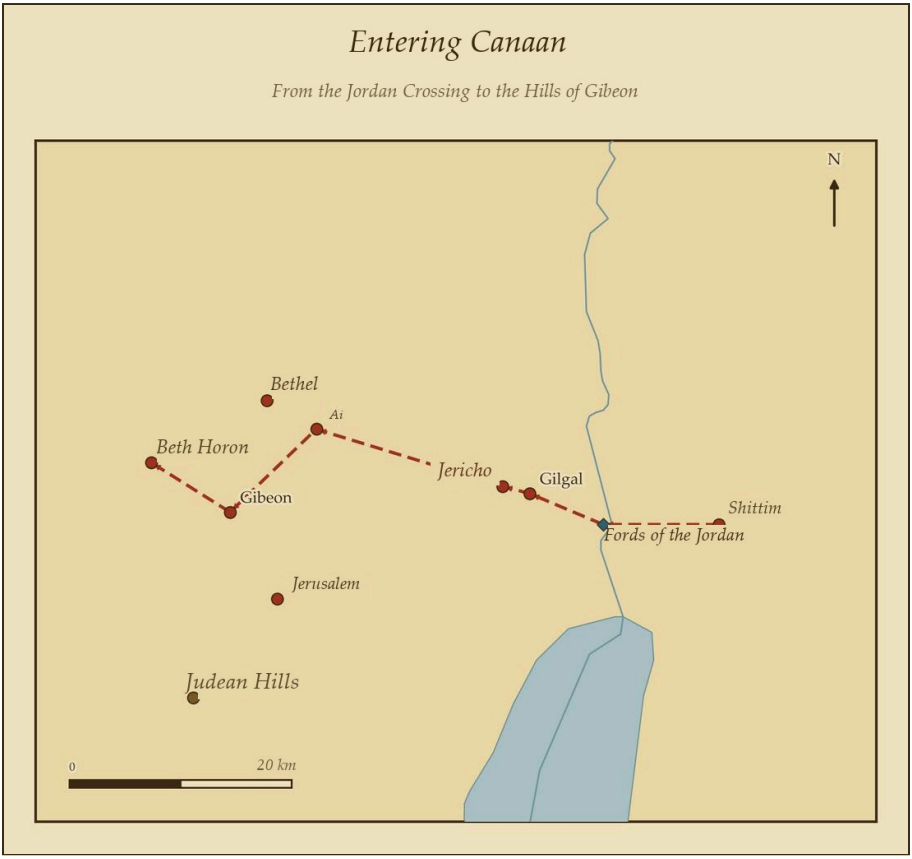
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

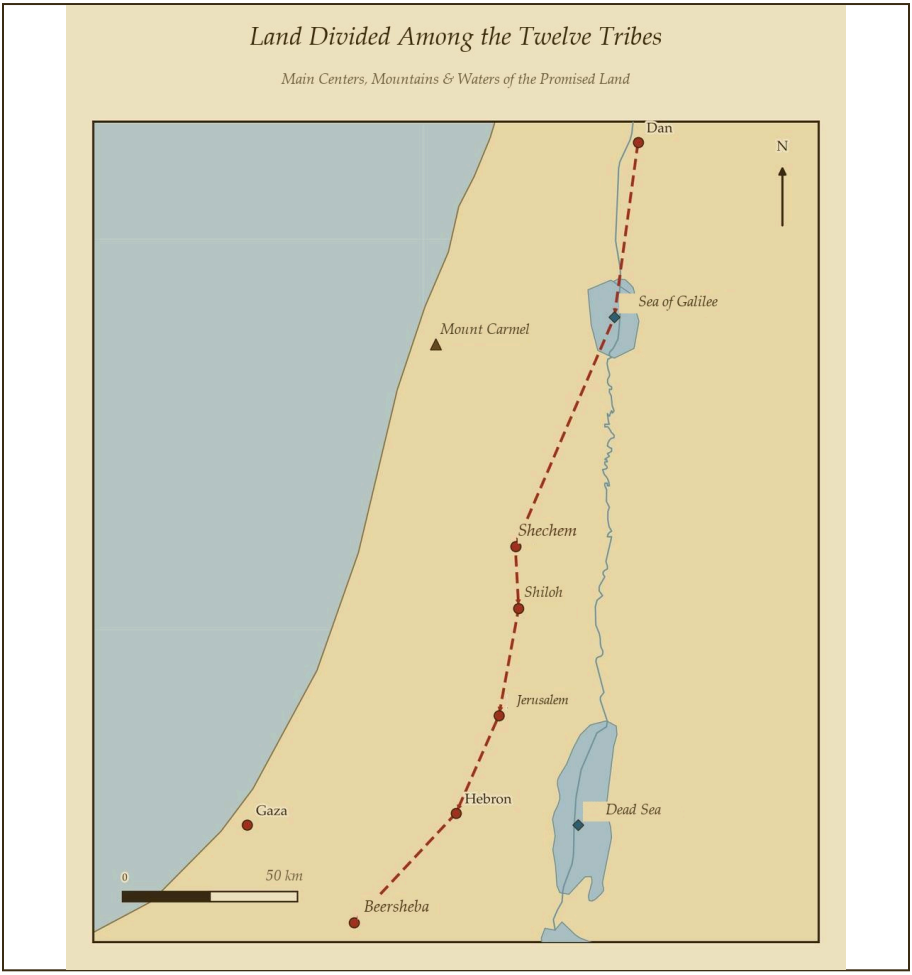
MAP 4.1



The red line shows the approximate course of the road from the Jordan up to the plateau. The locations are traditional, and the routes are approximate.

The map shows that the first phase of settlement was a march from the valley into the hills: from the deep Jordan rift to an elevation of nearly 800 m. Jericho controlled the entrance, Ai and Bethel lay on the edge of the plateau, and Gibeon close to present-day Jerusalem. Look closely at the difference in elevation, because it explains why the road was so exhausting and why ambushes in the ravines worked so well.

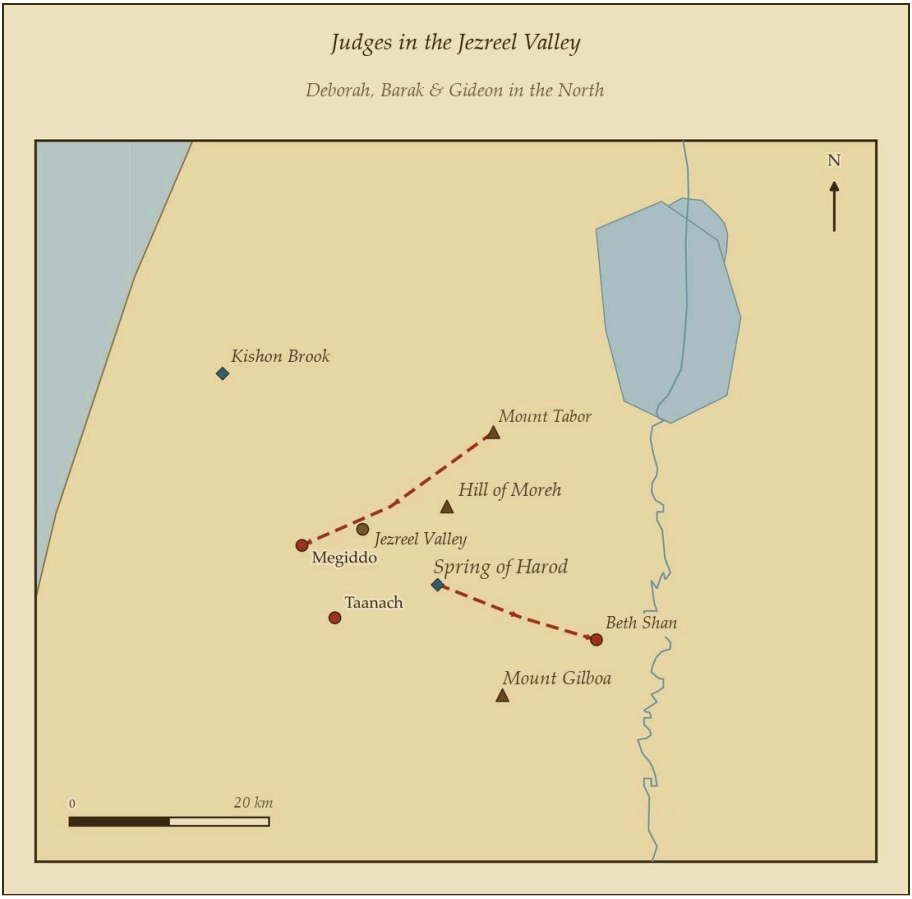
MAP 4.2



The map shows the backbone of the land from Dan in the north to Beersheba in the south, as the Bible describes it. The line marks the main route along the hills.

The map shows that the Promised Land stretches about 240 km from north to south, yet it is very narrow. The twelve tribes thus received strips of land of differing character: fertile valleys in the north, the hills of Ephraim in the middle, drier hills of Judah in the south. Shiloh, located almost in the center, was well suited as a place of assembly and for the Tabernacle.

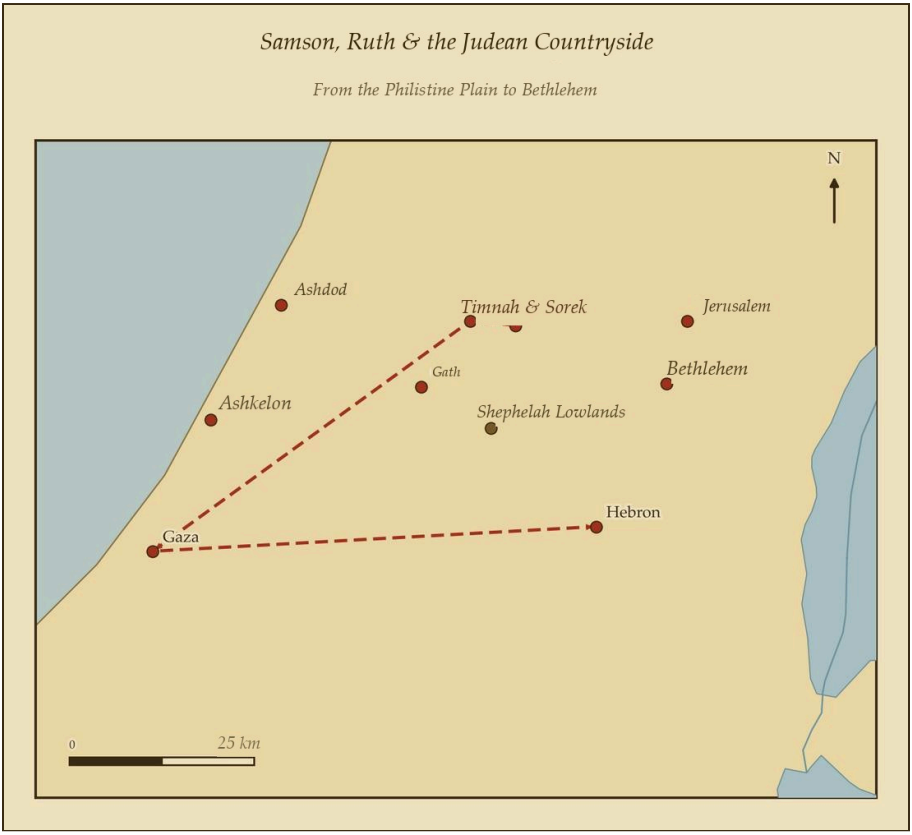
MAP 4.3



The map covers the broad Jezreel Valley, also called the Plain of Esdraelon, with the key sites of two battles. The lines show the approximate direction of the action.

The Jezreel Valley is the largest fertile area of the north and a natural corridor from the coast to the Jordan. That is why battles were fought here: that of Deborah and Barak in the rain, that of Gideon at night. Notice how Tabor, Gilboa, and the hill of Moreh mark the edges of the valley, giving defenders high ground and leaving attackers a trap of mud or darkness.

MAP 4.4



The map sets the five Philistine cities beside the hill country of Judah. The line shows Samson's approximate route, and Bethlehem marks the setting of Ruth's story.

The stories of Samson unfold on the border of two worlds: the coastal plain of the Philistines and the hills of Judah. The distances are small, yet the contrasts are enormous, since only a dozen or so kilometers separate the plain from the steep hills. Bethlehem, only about 8 km from Jerusalem, lies at the opposite end of this map and reminds us that daily life in Judah went on in the shadow of great history.

01 Crossing the Jordan and Gilgal

JOSH 3–5

The nation crosses the river on dry ground and pitches its first camp in Canaan.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a broad, fertile valley where a river winds between green thickets. In spring the water is muddy and swift, and crowds of people with their animals stand on both banks. In front are the priests, carrying the Ark high, with families behind them. On the horizon the pale hills of Judah rise, and far to the west, in the morning haze, the outline of Jericho can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the valley's landscape.

The Book of Joshua describes how the Israelites camped at Shittim and then moved toward the river opposite Jericho, at the season of the spring floods. The priests carrying the Ark of the Covenant stepped into the water first, and the current stopped, so that all the people crossed on dry ground. Twelve stones were taken from the riverbed, one for each tribe, and set up at Gilgal. The place became the first camp in Canaan, a site of circumcision and of celebrating the Passover. Tradition places Gilgal east of Jericho, though its exact location remains disputed.

The Jordan is not a wide river, but during the spring thaw its valley turns into a tangle of reeds, mud, and swift current. The river flows through a deep rift valley, below sea level, and its banks are overgrown with dense vegetation. Moving an entire people with their belongings across it was therefore a serious challenge. On the western side lay a belt of desert hills leading toward Jericho and onward, up to the plateau. The crossing thus had a strategic dimension as well: whoever controlled the ford controlled the entrance to the whole land.

FACTS

The Jordan Valley lies about 390 m below sea level, and here the river is only a few dozen meters wide.


N
Crossing the Jordan & Gilgal
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

02 Jericho

JOSH 2; 6

The first city of Canaan, which fell after seven days of marching around its walls.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a small but heavily fortified city on a low hill, surrounded by palm groves and fields irrigated by a spring. Walls of sun-dried brick rise several meters, and behind them the flat roofs of houses can be seen. All around spreads the bright, parched desert, and in the distance rocky slopes rise. The artistic reconstruction combines knowledge of the tell with the description of the oasis.

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho, who were hidden by Rahab, a woman of the city. Later the whole people circled the walls for six days, and on the seventh day seven times, with priests blowing horns. At the sound of a great shout the walls fell, and the city fell into Israelite hands. Rahab and her family were saved and joined the people. The story stresses that victory is a gift, not the fruit of strength. Jericho is identified with the tell of Tell es-Sultan, and the dating of its layers is a matter of debate among scholars.

Jericho lay beside an abundant spring, in an oasis amid the desert, and is one of the oldest known cities in the world. For this reason it was called the City of Palms. From here roads led west, through steep, dry ravines toward Jerusalem and Bethel, and east, through a ford on the Jordan. Whoever took Jericho opened the way into the mountain plateaus of Canaan. For newcomers from the desert it was thus the natural first task, and at the same time the symbolic beginning of settling the land.

FACTS

Jericho lies about 250 m below sea level and is among the lowest-lying cities in the world.


N
Jericho
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

03 Ai

JOSH 7–8

Defeat because of Achan's sin, and victory by ambush.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a rocky ridge covered with shrubs, with a small walled town on its summit. Narrow gullies wind all around, where a detachment could easily hide. The road uphill twists among the stones, and a dry, bright sky hangs over it all. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the lay of the land.

After the fall of Jericho, Joshua sent a small force against Ai, but the Israelites had to flee. The cause was the mysterious guilt of Achan, who had kept for himself items placed under a ban. When the matter came to light and the offender was punished, Joshua prepared a second attack. Part of the army was hidden in an ambush west of the city, while the rest feigned flight. The inhabitants rushed out of the gates in pursuit, and the ambush seized the city and set it on fire. Et-Tell is traditionally considered the location of Ai, though archaeologists dispute this identification.

Ai lay high on the edge of a hilly plateau, near Bethel, and the road from Jericho led there by a steep, difficult climb through dry ravines. The difference in elevation between the Jordan Valley and this place is several hundred meters, which explains why the first approach was so exhausting. The area is full of narrow valleys and rocky outcrops, ideal for hiding an ambush. For commanders it meant having to use the terrain, not just superior numbers, and the tactic of the second battle rests on exactly this.

FACTS

The distance from Jericho to Ai is about 20 km, with a climb of about 900 m.

04 Shechem, Ebal, and Gerizim

JOSH 8:30–35; 24

Two mountains above a valley, where the people heard the blessings and the warnings.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a greenish, fertile valley, with gentle but high mountains rising on both sides. Sheep graze on the slopes, and a road with merchant caravans runs between them. On one side the hills are covered with stone terraces, on the other with rock. The artistic reconstruction combines the biblical description with the appearance of the valley today.

The Book of Joshua describes a ceremony in the heart of the land. After the capture of Ai, the people gathered between two mountains: some stood at the foot of Gerizim, some at the foot of Ebal. Joshua built an altar and read out the words of the Law, including the blessings and the warnings. Many years later, near the end of his life, he again summoned all the tribes to Shechem and asked them to choose whom they would serve. The people answered that it would be the Lord, and Joshua recorded this as a renewal of the covenant.

Shechem lies in a natural pass between two massive mountains and controlled an important crossroads in the center of the land. The valley between Ebal and Gerizim is narrow, and sound carries superbly here, which made it easy for a large number of people to assemble together. The place was also close to the old patriarchs, for Abraham and Jacob had stopped here centuries before. Shechem thus became a natural place to recall that the promise reaches deeper than the mere conquest of the land.

FACTS

Mount Ebal rises about 940 m above sea level and Gerizim about 880 m; the valley between them is only about 500 m wide.

05 Gibeon

JOSH 9–10

A cunning alliance, the battle of Gibeon, and the day that grew longer.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

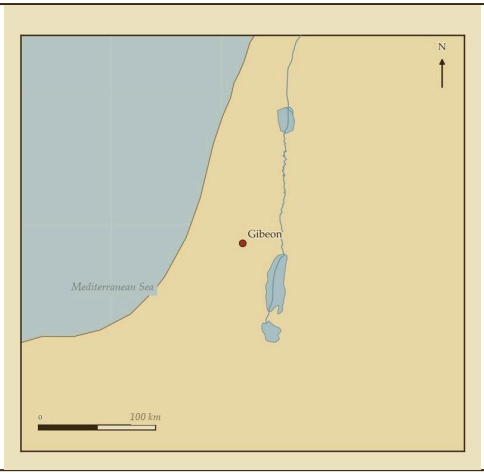
See a hill crowned by a city with stone walls, surrounded by terraces of vineyards and olive trees. Life bustles all around: carts, flocks, merchants. Down in the valley, clouds of dust rise as an army approaches. The sky is bright, and the light lingers long on the slopes. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description and surveys of the terrain.

The Gibeonites, seeing the fate of Jericho and Ai, came to the camp at Gilgal in worn-out clothes, pretending to be travelers from a distant land. The Israelites made a treaty with them, and when the trick came to light, they did not break their oath. Soon five kings attacked Gibeon. Joshua set out from Gilgal on a night march, surprised the enemy, and defeated them. Tradition describes the day as lengthened until the pursuit was over, and a hailstorm completed the enemy's defeat. The author stresses that it was not strength but God's intervention that decided the outcome.

Gibeon lay on the western edge of the plateau, not far from Jerusalem, on an important road leading from the hills toward the lowland. From Gilgal it took a whole night's march uphill, about 30 km along a steep, stony track. The pursuit then ran downhill through Beth-horon, a narrow pass where fleeing enemies could hardly scatter. This region formed a transitional belt between the hills and the lowland Shephelah, so whoever controlled it held the key to both worlds.

FACTS

Gibeon lies about 9 km northwest of Jerusalem, at about 800 m above sea level.


N
Gibeon
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

06 Shiloh

JOSH 18–19; 1 SAM 1–4

The site of the Tabernacle and of the casting of lots for the twelve tribes' portions.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a small hill above a greenish valley, on which stands a large tent covered with skins, surrounded by a courtyard. Around it are set up the smaller tents of pilgrims and stone enclosures. In spring and autumn crowds gather here. This is an artistic reconstruction, since the exact appearance of the Tabernacle at Shiloh is known to us only from descriptions.

Once the army had settled in the land, the Tent of Meeting was set up at Shiloh, and the whole people assembled there. Joshua noticed that seven tribes still had no portions assigned. So he sent three men from each of them to survey the land, and then, before the Lord, lots were cast and each tribe received its own territory. Judah and Joseph (Ephraim and Manasseh) had received their portions earlier, and the Levites were given cities among the other tribes. Later, Eli served at Shiloh, and Samuel as a boy.

Shiloh lies in the heart of the land, in the hills of Ephraim, in a valley hidden among low hills, not far from the main north–south route. From Shiloh to Shechem is about 18 km, and to Jerusalem about 31 km. This central position made it easier for pilgrims from different directions to reach the yearly feasts. The division of the land reflected geography: the north had fertile valleys, the hills of Ephraim pastures and vineyards, the south drier hills. The twelve tribes thus received very different living conditions.

FACTS

Shiloh lies about 600 m above sea level and about 31 km north of Jerusalem.

07 Taanach and Megiddo

JUDG 4–5

The battle by the Kishon brook and the victory of Deborah and Barak over Sisera's war chariots.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a broad, green plain under a heavy, dark sky. At its edge rise two fortified hills with cities, and in the valley wooden chariots with horses have bogged down. Streams of mud flow toward the brook, and in the distance Mount Tabor can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the valley's landscape.

The prophetess and judge Deborah, from the hill country of Ephraim, summoned Barak to gather men from Naphtali and Zebulun. Sisera, commander of King Jabin, had nine hundred iron chariots and assembled them at the Kishon. When Barak set out from Tabor, the Lord threw the enemy into confusion, and the valley turned to mud. The Song of Deborah mentions an overflowing brook that swept the chariots away. Sisera fled on foot and died in Jael's tent. In the text, Taanach and Megiddo are described as the site of the battle.

Taanach and Megiddo guarded the passes from the Jezreel Valley toward the coast. Through Megiddo ran one of the most important roads of the ancient world, linking Egypt with Mesopotamia, which meant that this place repeatedly became a battlefield. The Jezreel Valley is a broad plain with rich, heavy soil that turns to mud after a downpour. War chariots, fearsome on hard ground, bogged down here helplessly. Geography thus became an ally of the weaker side.

FACTS

Taanach and Megiddo are about 8 km apart, and the Jezreel Valley is about 20 km wide.


N
Taanach & Megiddo
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

08 Mount Tabor

JUDG 4:6–14

A lone, dome-shaped mountain from which Barak set out for battle.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a symmetrical mountain, covered with oaks and shrubs, rising majestically above a flat valley. On its slopes paths and a small gathering of people can be seen. Far below, clouds of dust or rain drift by. The artistic reconstruction is based on the mountain's appearance today.

Deborah told Barak to gather ten thousand men on Mount Tabor. When Sisera learned of it, he drew his chariots to the Kishon. Then Deborah told Barak that the day had come when the Lord would deliver the enemy into his hand. Barak came down the slope with his force and struck the enemy. Tabor marked the boundary between the territories of Zebulun, Naphtali, and Issachar, so it served as a natural gathering place for the tribes.

Tabor rises alone from the plain like an enormous, rounded dome. From its summit one can see the whole Jezreel Valley, the hills of Galilee, and the foothills of Carmel. This position offered an excellent vantage point, and the slope protected the army from a chariot charge, since chariots could not drive up it. Descending the mountain gave the Israelites the advantage of momentum, and the mud below deepened the enemy's confusion.

FACTS

Tabor rises about 588 m above sea level and about 400 m above the surrounding plain.

09 Spring of Harod

JUDG 6–7

Gideon sets out with three hundred warriors against the Midianites.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a quiet night over the valley. At the foot of a rocky slope a spring wells up, and in the distance, in the valley, hundreds of campfires of the Midianite camp flicker, with camels spread out like dark patches. On the hills sudden torchlights appear. An artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the night and the terrain.

The Midianites and their allies invaded the land every year at harvest time, leaving the Israelites in poverty. Gideon of Ophrah was called to be a judge. He gathered an army, but the Lord told him to reduce it. First the fearful were sent home, then the men were tested by how they drank water from the spring, until three hundred remained. At night Gideon divided them into three companies and gave them trumpets, empty jars, and torches. At the agreed signal they smashed the jars and blew the trumpets, and the enemy began to flee in panic.

The spring of Harod lies at the foot of Mount Gilboa, on the edge of the Jezreel Valley, and the Midianite camp stood north of it, in the valley below the hill of Moreh. From this place the way to the Jordan, about 15 km to the east, lay open to the fleeing. Gideon used the darkness of night, the breadth of the valley, and the echo to give the impression of an enormous army. The narrow passes and hill edges drove the fugitives toward the fords of the river.

FACTS

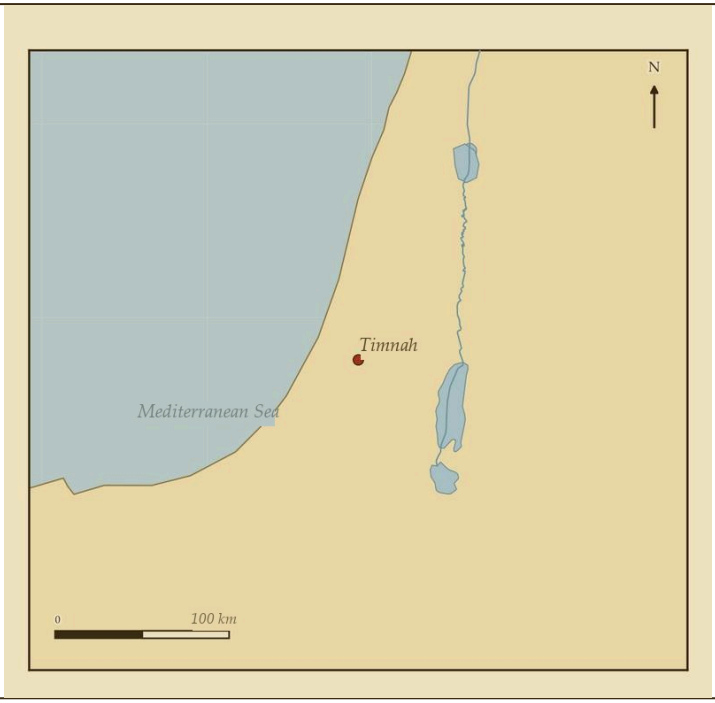
The distance from the spring of Harod to the Jordan is about 15 km, and according to the text the Midianite camp numbered hundreds of thousands of people and camels.


N
Spring of Harod
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

10 Timnah

JUDG 14

A Philistine city where Samson fell in love with a woman and posed a riddle.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a wide valley with gentle slopes, with grain fields, vineyards, and a small town on a hill. Farmsteads stand all around, and shepherds and carts can be seen on the roads. In the distance, to the east, the rocky hills of Judah rise. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the borderland.

Samson came from the tribe of Dan, from the town of Zorah. When he grew up, he saw a young Philistine woman in Timnah and asked his parents to get her for him as a wife. On the way to Timnah he killed a lion with his bare hands, and later found honey in its carcass. At the wedding feast he made a riddle of it for thirty guests, wagering garments. When the answer came out through his wife, Samson flew into a rage and began a series of deeds that unleashed open war with the Philistines.

Timnah lay in the Sorek Valley, about 5 km from Zorah, on the border between the hills of Judah and the coastal plain. It was a borderland, where Israelites and Philistines met, traded goods, and intermarried. The Sorek Valley formed a natural corridor from the coast into the hills. That is why all the tensions between the two peoples played out in places like this, and the story of Samson shows this world of borders well.

FACTS

Timnah (Tel Batash) lies about 5 km from Zorah and about 25 km from the sea.

11 Gaza

JUDG 16

A Philistine city from which Samson carried the gates up to a hilltop.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a fortified city on a sandy hill, surrounded by palm groves and gardens. The walls of brick and stone are broad, with a massive gate with wooden doors set in them. Beyond the city stretch the plain and the distant sea, and in the far distance gentle hills rise. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on knowledge of Philistine cities.

4.11 · GAZA · JUDG 16

Samson came to Gaza, where the Philistines shut the city gates, planning to catch him at dawn. In the middle of the night he rose, tore out the gates together with their posts, and carried them to the top of a hill facing Hebron. Later Delilah, a woman from the Sorek Valley, betrayed his secret, and the Philistines seized him, blinded him, and brought him to Gaza. Imprisoned, he worked at the mill, until in the temple of Dagon, during a festival, he asked the Lord for one last measure of strength and brought down the pillars, dying together with his enemies.

Gaza lay at the southern end of the coastal plain, about 5 km from the sea, on the great route linking Egypt with Syria and Mesopotamia. It was one of the largest Philistine cities, wealthy through trade. The distance from Gaza to Hebron is about 60 km, with the last twenty-odd steeply uphill. Samson's feat was thus not only a miracle of strength but also a symbol of the city's humiliation, whose gates were carried right up to the hills of Judah.

FACTS

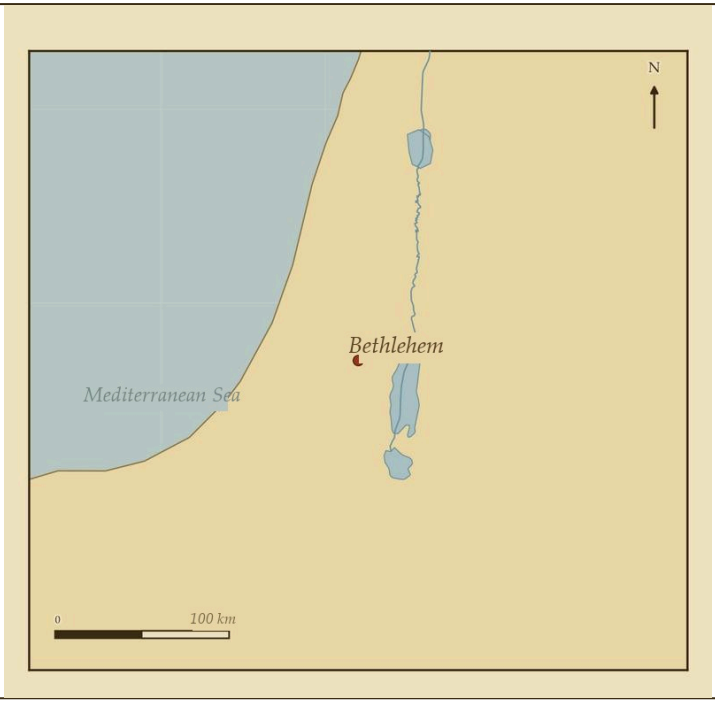
Gaza lies about 5 km from the Mediterranean Sea and about 60 km from Hebron.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Gaza
0
100 km

12 Bethlehem

RUTH 1–4

The barley fields where Ruth met Boaz, and the beginning of David's family line.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine golden barley fields on terraces, harvested by hand by reapers. Women gather the ears of grain, carrying them in bundles, and in the background the small stone houses of the hilltop town can be seen. Olive and fig trees grow all around, and farther off pale slopes rise. An artistic reconstruction, based on the landscape of the area today.

Because of famine, Elimelech and his family left Bethlehem and settled in Moab. After the death of her husband and sons, Naomi decided to return, and her daughter-in-law Ruth went with her. In Bethlehem the barley harvest was beginning. Ruth went out to the fields to glean, and happened upon the field of Boaz, a relative of Naomi. Boaz saw to her safety, and after fulfilling the requirements of the law, he married her. From their family was born Obed, father of Jesse and thus grandfather of King David.

Bethlehem lies on a ridge of the hills of Judah, about 8 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 770 m above sea level. The area is fertile, but the transition from fields to desert is short here, which explains both the periodic famines and the pastoral tradition. The hillsides form terraces of barley and wheat, and lower down, toward the Dead Sea, the Judean Desert begins. The road from Hebron to Jerusalem ran through Bethlehem.

FACTS

Bethlehem lies about 770 m above sea level and about 8 km from Jerusalem.

Reflection Questions

1. How does the lay of the land, from the Jordan Valley to the Jezreel Valley, help us understand the course of the battles described, and why is victory attributed not only to the strength of men?

2. Why did Shiloh and Shechem play such an important role in the religious life of the nation, and what do they have to do with the memory of the covenant and the division of the land?

3. What does the story of Ruth and the fields of Bethlehem say about faithfulness, hospitality, and the way God's plan can unfold in ordinary, everyday matters?